

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 143

Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1958-1966

Coverage Date: 1958-1966

Place Coverage: G/Wi, Ghanzi District, Botswana

Section Title(S)

Joking and respect • The G/wi kinship system

The figures illustrate the terminology of the system in its primary extent.

602

Kin Relationships

608

Artificial Kin Relationships

612

Kindreds And Ramages

Joking and respect

The relationships an individual has with his kin are classified as either joking or avoidance/respect relationships. The structure is ego-centered and therefore varies from one individual to another, precluding a group-wide uniformity in the dichotomy that could constitute anything resembling a moiety organization. In general, all kin are in a joking relationship except one's parents and opposite-sex siblings and their classificatory and fictional equivalents, who are in the avoidance/respect category. The relationships are dyadic and reciprocal, conceived of as existing between pairs of individuals, each having the same category of relationship with the other.

602

Kin Relationships

An avoidance/respect relationship, (*gjiukxekxu*) requires that those so related should *#ao* (*v.t.*, to be reserved or respectful toward, to be scared of) one another. Their proper behavior is characterized by:

561

Age Stratification

602

- Not sitting close together, and generally avoiding bodily contact if not of the same sex

Kin Relationships
- Being careful not to swear or make bawdy remarks in the obvious hearing of those in an avoidance relationship
- Not touching their possessions without permission; if an object is to be passed between avoidance relatives, an intermediary should, properly, be used and a direct transfer avoided
- Younger persons use the honorific plural form when addressing their elders

Children are not expected to observe this etiquette rigidly until they are 7 or 8 years old. Within the confines of respectful etiquette, a great affection is displayed and expressed between parents and children and between brothers and sisters. The reserved behavior is consistent with the reinforcement of the prohibition of incest between brother and sister and with the exercise of parental authority over children. The latter is the only G/wi relationship in which authority is intrinsic.

602

Kin Relationships

858

Status Of Children

Although I have formally dichotomized the two types of relationship, there is a gradation of decreasing reserve in joking relationships. Behavior  144Behav-toward one's grandparents lacks many of the restraints of relationships with one's parents but is less free than that between cross-cousins of the same sex and approximate age. The last is ideally close and friendly. Property may be used without asking permission, conversation is unrestrained, and physical contact is the normal expression of friendship between young adolescent girls. Sharply critical comment on joking partners is permitted in public and conversational duels are frequent. Older boys and girls and, less commonly, adult men and women spice their exchanges with ingeniously bawdy gibes.

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Material Not Relevant

593

Family Relationships

602

Kin Relationships

603

Grandparents And Grandchildren

605

Cousins

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